> regards the wives of the kings, they are in the habit of burning them, whether they wish it or not, by which they desire to prevent any of them by chance committing something unworthy of the illustrious husband. They make an exception only for women of advanced years and for those who have children; for the son is the responsible protector of his mother.

When a person dies, the surviving heirs ‘are to wash, embalm, wrap [the body] in a shroud, and then to burn it with as much sandal and other wood as they can get’. After the cremation, the attendees all ‘wash themselves as well as their dresses during two days, because they have become unclean by touching the dead’. If the ashes can’t be consigned to the Ganga, a nearby brook is chosen. ‘If the heir is a son, he must during the whole year wear mourning dress; he must mourn and have no intercourse with women’. Inheritance follows patriarchal norms; the daughter gets a quarter of the son’s inheritance. A wildcard clause could make things unpleasant for the heirs: ‘The debts of the deceased must be paid by his heir’, whether or not the deceased has left any inheritance. The widow inherits nothing. If she ‘does not burn herself, but prefers to remain alive, the [male] heir of her deceased husband has to provide her with nourishment and clothing as long as she lives’. If she doesn’t have a son, she is at the mercy of other male relatives.

Alberuni approached India like a scholarly journalist. We could as well call him the first Indologist. As with so many early travellers, he didn’t speak about his own life and mainly aspired to ‘place before the reader the theories of the Hindus exactly as they are’. *India* is the work of a deeply intelligent, curious and decent mind. Alberuni ends *India* with a simple prayer: ‘We ask God to pardon us for every statement of ours which is not true.’